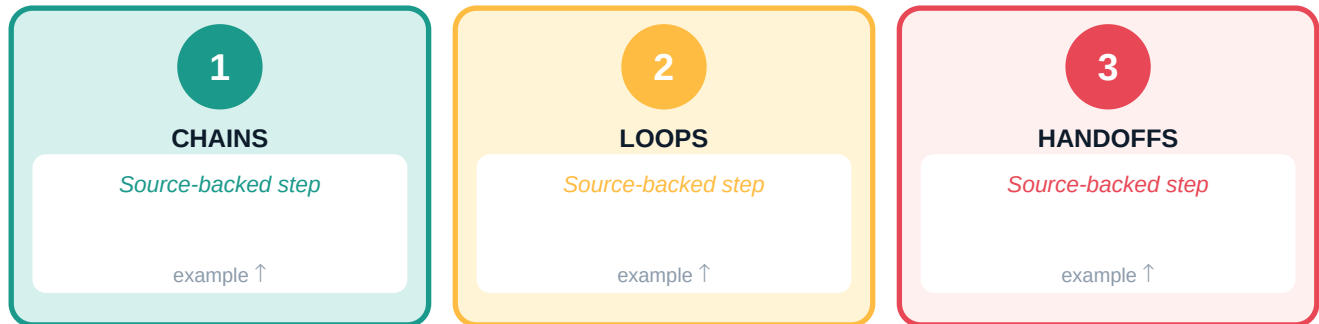


Chains, Loops, and Handoffs



START WITH A COMPLETE WORKFLOW Before naming the mechanics, look at what a useful workflow feels like in practice. David needs to produce a client brief from call notes, emails, and earlier project context:

- AI extracts the client's requirements and uncertainties.
- David reviews the extraction, corrects one mistake, and adds two missing requirements.
- AI proposes a structure for the brief.
- David approves the structure before AI drafts it.
- AI drafts the brief section by section.
- AI critiques the draft against the agreed brief.
- AI revises the draft, and David makes the final decision about what can be sent.

The quality comes from the connections between the stages: clear outputs, deliberate human review, and a defined standard for improvement. Now we can name the three mechanics that make those connections work.

THE BUILDING BLOCKS OF COMPLEX WORKFLOWS Chapter 17 introduced decomposition patterns. This chapter introduces the mechanics of connecting stages together, the "plumbing" of multi-step AI workflows.

Three mechanics cover most of what you will encounter:

Chains, Sequential stages where each output becomes the next input **Loops**, Iterative cycles where output is reviewed and refined until it meets a standard **Handoffs**, Points where the work passes from AI to a human (or vice versa) for a specific contribution

Understanding which mechanic applies to which part of a task is what turns a list of stages into a functioning workflow.



THREE WORKFLOW MECHANICS

Chain Loop Handoff A -> B -> C Produce -> Review AI ↔ Human Each output becomes -> -> Improve -> Judgment enters at a the next input. Repeat until the deliberate control standard is met. point.

CHAINS A chain is the simplest multi-step pattern: A -> B -> C. Each step's output is the input to the next.

The key discipline in a chain is maintaining coherence: each step should produce output that is complete enough and well-formed enough to be a useful input to the next step. If Step 2 depends on Step 1 and Step 1 is mediocre, Step 3 will inherit and amplify that mediocrity.

THE CHAIN DISCIPLINE: Review each step's output before proceeding to the next If a step's output is substantially wrong, correct it before proceeding Be explicit about what carries forward: "Using the outline from Step 1, now draft Section 3"

LOOPS A loop is an iterative cycle: Produce -> Review -> Improve -> (Review again) -> (Improve again) -> Done.

Loops are appropriate when:

The quality bar is high and the first draft is unlikely to meet it The criteria for success are explicit and can be systematically applied

Chapter 19 - Chains, Loops, and Handoffs

Time spent iterating is less than time spent correcting downstream

The critique loop in Chapter 18 is a loop. So is any scenario where you are refining a draft toward a specific standard.

THE LOOP DISCIPLINE: Define what "done" looks like before you start looping, otherwise loops run indefinitely Be specific about what is wrong in each review cycle, vague feedback produces marginal improvement Know when to stop: a document that is 90% right and been through two loops is usually better to complete by hand than to loop a third time

HANDOFFS A handoff is a point where the work passes between AI and human. Handoffs are not failures, they are deliberate design choices about where human judgment adds value that AI cannot.

The best workflows design handoffs deliberately:

AI -> Human handoffs occur when:

AI has produced material that needs human judgment to evaluate (is this claim actually correct?) The next step requires knowledge AI doesn't have (what does the client actually want?) A decision needs to be made that carries accountability (does this represent our position?) The work will be put in front of someone who needs to trust it

Human -> AI handoffs occur when:

A human has made a judgment that AI should now implement (here's the structure I want, now draft it)



PART IV - FROM PROMPTS TO WORKFLOWS

New information has arrived that AI needs to incorporate (here's their response, now draft a reply) A human review has identified specific changes that AI should make

PRO TIP DOCUMENT YOUR BEST WORKFLOWS. WHEN YOU DESIGN A WORKFLOW THAT WORKS WELL FOR A TYPE OF TASK,

WATCH OUT OVER-ENGINEERED WORKFLOWS ADD OVERHEAD WITHOUT PROPORTIONATE BENEFIT. A THREE-PARAGRAPH

WHAT PART IV HAS ESTABLISHED You can now design and execute multi-step AI workflows:

Recognise when a task requires multiple stages Break tasks into stages with clear deliverables and handoff points Apply three decomposition patterns to different task types Use the critique loop to improve drafts systematically

Chapter 19 - Chains, Loops, and Handoffs

Connect stages with chains, loops, and deliberate handoffs

Part V applies these skills to twenty-five specific, tested workflows across the most common professional and personal use cases.



PART IV - FROM PROMPTS TO WORKFLOWS

PART V 25 Real-World Workflows

Part V is a reference library. These twenty-five workflows are tested, structured, and ready to use, or adapt for your specific situation. Each follows the same format: Situation, Steps with exact prompts, Verification, and Customisation notes.

How to use this section: find the workflow closest to what you need. Read the Situation to confirm it's a good match. Run the Steps. Follow the Verification. Then read Customisation to adapt it to your specific circumstances.

Placeholders appear in [BRACKETS]. Replace them with your specific content before running.

Find a workflow by time and complexity Use this as a quick starting point. The times are estimates for a prepared user with the necessary source material available; the work still needs proportionate review.



TYPICAL STARTING POINT TIME WORKFLOWS

Quick win, one clear task About 5 W1, W4, W9, W19, W24 minutes

Medium build, several 15-30 W2, W3, W6, W8, W10, W13, prompts and a review minutes W16, W20

Deep work, source 30+ W5, W7, W14, W15, W17, W18, material, stages, or minutes W21, W22, W23, W25 decisions

Start with the nearest match for your situation, then choose the simplest level that is safe for the stakes. A complex workflow is useful when the work is complex; it is unnecessary overhead for a short, low-risk task.



FIND A WORKFLOW BY TIME AND COMPLEXITY



QUICK WIN W1 - W4 - W9 - W19 - W24



MEDIUM BUILD W2 - W3 - W6 - W8 - W10 - W13 - W16 - W20



DEEP WORK W5 - W7 - W14 - W15 - W17 - W18 - W21 - W22 - W23 - W25



BUSINESS AND PROFESSIONAL



W 1 , WRITE AND IMPROVE A PROFESSIONAL EMAIL TIME : ABOUT 5 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY

SITUATION You need to write an email that matters, a client communication, a proposal follow-up, a difficult message to a colleague, a professional introduction. The stakes are high enough that you don't want to draft it without a second opinion.

STEP 1, PROVIDE CONTEXT

I need to write a professional email. Here is the context:

Sender: [Your name, role, organisation] Recipient: [Name, role, organisation, relationship to you]
Purpose of the email: [What you want to achieve with this email] Background: [Relevant history, context, what's happened so far] Tone required: [Formal / professional-informal / warm / firm] Key constraints: [Anything this email must not say or do] Desired response or outcome: [What you want the recipient to do or feel after reading it] Length preference: [Brief / medium / thorough]

Please draft this email.

STEP 2, CRITIQUE THE DRAFT

Review the email you just drafted. Evaluate it on: Is the purpose immediately clear? Is the tone right for the relationship? Could anything be misinterpreted? Is anything missing that the recipient needs to act on this? Is it the right length?

Be direct about any problems.

STEP 3, REVISE

Revise the email addressing the issues you identified. [Add any additional changes you want: "Also, make the opening less formal" / "Remove the third paragraph" / "Add a clear call to action at the end."]

VERIFICATION Before sending: Does it say what you intend? Read it from the recipient's perspective. Would the tone land as intended? Is there anything that could be misconstrued? If the email involves any commitment, fact, or number, verify it independently.

W

W1, Write and Improve a Professional Email

C U S T O M I S E For internal communications: reduce formality, increase directness For client complaints: add "The tone must acknowledge their frustration without admitting liability or making commitments we haven't authorised" to Step 1 For cold outreach: add "This person does not know me, so make the value proposition clear within the first two sentences" For difficult personal situations: add context about the relationship history and the sensitivity required

!

W 2 , PRE PARE FOR A DIFFICU LT CONVERS ATION

!

TIME : 1 5 - 3 0 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: MEDIUM BUILD

S I T U AT I O N You have a conversation coming up that you are not looking forward to. Performance review. Negotiation. Complaint. Conflict. Family tension. You want to go in prepared, not reactive.

STEP 1 , DEFINE THE CONVERS ATION

I have a difficult conversation to prepare for. Please help me prepare.

Situation: [What is happening and why this conversation is needed] **Who I'm talking to:** [Their role, your relationship, relevant background] **What I want to achieve:** [The ideal outcome of this conversation for you] **What I'm worried about:** [The scenarios I'm dreading or want to avoid] **My position:** [What my bottom line is, what I'm willing to do] **Their likely position:** [What you expect they want or will say]

STEP 2, MAP THEIR PERSPECTIVE

Help me understand their perspective as fully as possible.

What legitimate concerns or interests might they have? What might they feel about this conversation before it starts? What outcome might they be hoping for? What would make this conversation go well from their point of view?

I want to understand their side, not just my own.

STEP 3, PREPARE FOR LIKELY SCENARIOS

Based on what we've established, what are the three or four most likely ways this conversation could go? For each scenario, what is the key thing I need to do or say to steer it toward a good outcome?

STEP 4, DRAFT KEY STATEMENTS

Help me draft the key things I need to say clearly: 1. My opening statement (what I'll say to start the conversation) 2. My core position, stated clearly but not aggressively 3. A response to their most likely pushback

Tone: [Firm and direct / Warm and collaborative / Measured and professional]

VERIFICATION Is the opening statement something you could actually say without it feeling scripted or artificial? Have you considered their perspective genuinely, not just strategically? If the conversation involves any specific commitments, facts, or numbers, confirm these before you go in.

CUSTOMISE For performance conversations with a direct report: add HR policy context and any documentation you have For negotiation: add "I also want to identify possible compromise positions between our positions"

W

W2, Prepare for a Difficult Conversation

For family situations: adjust tone instructions significantly and focus Steps 2 and 3 more heavily on empathy For complaints: add "I want to be assertive without being hostile"

!

W 3 , RESEARCH A TOPIC FOR A MEETING TIME : 1 5 - 3 0 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: MEDIUM B

S I T U A T I O N You have a meeting coming up on a topic you need to know more about. You want to be prepared enough to contribute intelligently without spending hours reading primary material.

STEP 1 , ES TABLISH THE KNOWLEDGE REQUIREMENT

I have a meeting in [timeframe] about [topic]. I need to be well-prepared.

My current knowledge level: [None / Basic / Some background] Who else will be in the meeting: [Roles and expertise level] The likely agenda or decisions: [What the meeting will cover] What I need to be able to do: [Contribute / Ask intelligent questions / Understand what others are saying / Make a recommendation]

Please give me a briefing on [topic] pitched at the right level for my knowledge and this context.

STEP 2 , IDENTIFY KNOWLEDGE GAPS

Based on what you've told me, what are the three to five things I most need to understand clearly before this meeting? What are the key terms or concepts I should be familiar with? What questions should I be ready to answer?

STEP 3 , PREPARE QUESTIONS

What would be the most intelligent questions I could ask in this meeting to contribute productively and demonstrate I've prepared? Focus on questions that move the meeting forward, not just questions that demonstrate my knowledge.

VERIFICATION AI briefings are starting points, not authoritative sources. Verify any specific facts, statistics, or claims you intend to cite in the meeting. Confirm current information for any fast-moving topics (technology, regulation, markets). If the meeting involves decisions with significant consequences, supplement AI preparation with primary sources.

CUSTOMISE For technical topics: ask AI explicitly to explain technical concepts in plain language before introducing the terminology For regulatory topics: add "Focus particularly on the current regulatory position and flag any areas of uncertainty or ongoing change" For commercially sensitive topics: structure the briefing around the business context, not just the technical content



W 4 , SUMMARISE A LONG DOCUMENT TIME : ABOUT 5 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: QUICK WIN

SITUATION You have a document that is too long to read fully in the time available, or you need to extract specific information efficiently. The document might be a report, a policy, a contract, a research paper, or a lengthy email chain.

STEP 1, UPLOAD AND INSTRUCT

Please read the document I'm attaching. [Attach document.]

Before summarising, tell me: how long is this document, what type of document is it, and what appear to be its main sections?

STEP 2, TARGETED SUMMARY

Now produce a summary for the following purpose:

Audience: [Who will read or use this summary] Purpose: [What decision, action, or understanding this summary will support] What to include: [Key findings / Main arguments / Action items / Financial figures / Decisions made / Recommendations] What to exclude: [Background information already known / Technical detail not needed / Appendices] Length: [Two paragraphs / Five bullet points / One page] Format: [Prose / Bullet points / Table / Structured sections]

STEP 3, FLAG WHAT NEEDS ATTENTION

Now separately: 1. What are the most important facts, numbers, or claims in this document that I should verify independently? 2. Were there any sections of the document that you found ambiguous or that required assumptions? 3. Is there anything in the document that seems unusual, surprising, or that a careful reader should notice?

VERIFICATION Check at least two specific facts extracted from the document against the source text. Verify any numbers or figures independently. If the document is a contract or legal instrument, the plain-language summary is a starting point, do not act on it without reference to the original language for anything that matters.



PART V - 25 REAL-WORLD WORKFLOWS

C U S T O M I S E For contracts: add "Specifically flag: any obligations on us, any deadlines, any unusual clauses, and any terms that differ from standard commercial practice" For research papers: add "Evaluate the strength of the evidence. What is the methodology? What are the limitations the authors acknowledge?" For meeting notes/transcripts: add "Extract all action items with owner and deadline. Identify all decisions made." For financial documents: add "Flag any calculation that relies on an assumption I should verify"



W 5 , DRAFT A PROJECT PROPOSAL TIME : 3 0 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK

S I T U A T I O N You need to write a proposal for a project, internal or external, that makes a clear case for the project, describes the approach, and asks for approval or resources.

STEP 1, GATHER INFORMATION

I need to write a project proposal. Before drafting, help me structure the content.

Project name: [Name] Proposing to: [Who will approve this, their role and decision-making context] What the project will do: [Summary of the project] The problem it solves: [What is not working now / what opportunity is being missed] The proposed approach: [How you will do it] Resources needed: [Time, money, people] Expected outcomes: [What success looks like, ideally with measurable indicators] Risks: [What might go wrong] Timeline: [When it will happen]

Given this, what information am I missing that a strong proposal should include?

STEP 2, STRUCTURE THE PROPOSAL

Based on what we've established, propose a document structure for this proposal. The reader is [decision-maker's role]. They will want to know: does this project make sense, is the approach credible, and is the case for investment compelling?

Suggest section headings with one sentence on what each section should achieve.

STEP 3, DRAFT SECTION BY SECTION

Now draft Section 1: [name]. Key points: [from your structure plan] Length: [specification] Tone: [professional / business-like / persuasive but evidence-based]

[Repeat for each section, reviewing between sections.]



PART V - 25 REAL-WORLD WORKFLOWS

STEP 4, CRITIQUE AND REFINE

Review the complete proposal. As a decision-maker who has seen many project proposals: What is the most compelling element? What is the weakest element? What questions would you still have after reading this? Is the case for the resources requested clearly made?

V E R I F I C A T I O N Verify any financial figures. Check that outcomes are genuinely measurable as stated. Ensure any claimed precedents or comparisons are accurate. Have someone familiar with the decision-maker's perspective review before submission.

C U S T O M I S E For internal proposals: reduce formality, increase emphasis on operational impact and resource efficiency For external bids: add the client's evaluation criteria explicitly and verify the proposal addresses each one For new budget requests: add a cost-benefit analysis section and ensure the return on investment is explicitly stated



W 6 , WRITE A JOB POSTING



TIME : 1 5 - 3 0 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: MEDIUM BUILD

S I T U A T I O N You need to attract the right candidates to a role without writing something generic that attracts everyone and therefore no one.

STEP 1, DEFINE THE ROLE

Help me write a job posting. Here is the role:

Role title: [Title] Organisation: [Company name and brief description] What this person will actually do: [Day-to-day responsibilities] Who they will work with: [Team, reporting line, stakeholders] What makes someone great at this role: [Skills, experience, behaviours, be specific] What makes this role attractive: [Why would the right person want this job?] Essential requirements: [Non-negotiable qualifications or

experience] Desirable but not essential: [Preferences] Salary range: [If disclosable]
Location/remote/hybrid: [Working arrangement]

Any particular types of candidates you want to attract or avoid?

STEP 2, DRAFT THE POSTING

Write the job posting.

Tone: [Professional and direct / Warm and human / Formal] Length: [Standard job board format, concise / Detailed]

Avoid: clichés like "dynamic team player", "fast-paced environment", "passionate", "hit the ground running". Write in plain language that describes the actual role and what we're looking for.

STEP 3, TEST THE POSTING

Read this posting as a strong candidate who is browsing job boards quickly. Does the role stand out? Is it clear what they'd be doing day-to-day? Is it clear what kind of person would succeed here? Would a great candidate self-select in, or would they skip past it?

What would make it stronger?



PART V - 25 REAL-WORLD WORKFLOWS

VERIFICATION Have the hiring manager review for accuracy, AI may have emphasised the wrong things. Check that essential requirements are genuinely essential (unnecessarily restrictive requirements are both wasteful and a legal risk in many jurisdictions). Verify compliance with any applicable equal opportunities or advertising requirements.

CUSTOMISE For specialist technical roles: add a technical requirements section and be specific about tools and technologies required For senior leadership roles: emphasise strategic aspects and leadership behaviours over task descriptions For organisations with strong cultures: add context about the culture and be honest about what makes the organisation unusual



W 7 , PREPARE A CLIENT REPORT TIME : 30 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK

SITUATION You need to produce a client-facing report that summarises work done, findings, or recommendations. The report must be professional, clear, and demonstrate value.

STEP 1, GATHER AND STRUCTURE CONTENT

I'm producing a client report. Please help me structure it.

Client: [Name, type of organisation, relationship] Purpose of the report: [What it covers and why the client needs it] What I have to work with: [The source material I'm going to attach or describe] What the client cares most about: [Their priorities, cost, risk, growth, efficiency, etc.] What we want them to do or

feel after reading: [Approval, action, confidence, etc.] Format requirements: [Any specified format / Our standard format] Length: [Approximate]

Please propose a report structure with the most important content first.

STEP 2, DRAFT FROM SOURCE MATERIAL

[Attach or paste source material]

Draft the report using this source material. Follow the proposed structure. Write for the client, assume they are [knowledge level] about this topic. Professional tone, plain language, no unnecessary jargon.

STEP 3, EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Now write the executive summary: The client's situation and what we were asked to do The most important three to five findings or conclusions What we recommend they do next Length: One page maximum. Read-first, not read-last.



PART V - 25 REAL-WORLD WORKFLOWS

STEP 4, REVIEW

Review this report as if you are the client receiving it. Is the most important information easy to find? Is there anything that is unclear or requires background knowledge the client might not have? Is there anything missing that a client would reasonably expect to see? Is the visual structure (headings, paragraphs, any tables) easy to navigate?

V E R I F I C A T I O N Verify all statistics, financial figures, and dates against source material. Check that recommendations are logically supported by the findings. Have a colleague read it who has not been close to the work, they will catch assumptions you've made that the client won't share.



W 8 , C R E A T E A M E E T I N G A G E N D A A N D F O L L O W - U P



T I M E : 1 5 - 3 0 M I N U T E S - C O M P L E X I T Y : M E D I U M B U I L D

S I T U A T I O N You are running a meeting that needs to produce decisions or actions, not just discussion. You want an agenda that focuses the meeting, and a follow-up that records what happened clearly.

STEP 1, DESIGN THE AGENDA

I'm running a [type] meeting with [participants and their roles].

Purpose of this meeting: [What decisions need to be made / what needs to be resolved / what needs to be planned] Time available: [Duration] Background context: [What situation this meeting is responding to]

Please design an agenda that: Allocates time to each item proportional to its importance Puts decisions before discussion where possible Identifies who leads each item Ends with clear next steps

Include: a pre-read list if relevant, any materials that should be prepared in advance.

STEP 2, POST-MEETING NOTES -> FOLLOW-UP

Here are my notes from the meeting: [paste notes / attach transcript or notes document]

Please produce a meeting follow-up document containing: 1. Decisions made (what was agreed) 2. Actions (who does what by when) 3. Topics tabled for another time 4. Any open questions not resolved

Format: brief and structured. This will be sent to all participants within 24 hours of the meeting.

VERIFICATION Circulate the actions list to attendees for confirmation before sending, memory of who committed to what diverges quickly. Verify any facts or figures noted in the meeting before recording them as agreed.



PART V - 25 REAL-WORLD WORKFLOWS



MARKETING AND CONTENT



W 9 , WRITE A LINKEDIN POST TIME : ABOUT 5 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: QUICK WIN

S I T U AT I O N You want to publish something on LinkedIn that is genuinely worth reading, not corporate content or hollow inspiration, but something that says something real.

STEP 1 , DEFINE THE CONTENT

I want to write a LinkedIn post. Here is what I want to share:

My point of view: [What I think / what I've observed / what I've learned] The insight: [Why this matters or why it's worth saying] Any story or example: [A specific situation or experience that illustrates the point] My audience: [Who I'm writing for, industry, role, interest] My usual voice on LinkedIn: [Formal / conversational / technical / personal] Engagement goal: [Spark discussion / share expertise / build visibility / announce something]

Any example of a post I've written that I liked? [Paste it if so]

STEP 2 , DRAFT

Write the LinkedIn post.

Length: [Short (100-150 words) / Medium (200-250) / Long (300-400)] Format: [Prose / Hook + body / Numbered points / Story structure] Do not use: hollow inspiration, vague motivational filler, "I'm excited to announce", "game-changing", or any phrase that reads like AI wrote it. First line must make

someone stop scrolling.

STEP 3, TEST THE OPENING

Read only the first sentence. Would someone who doesn't know me stop scrolling to read the rest? If not, write three alternative opening sentences that would.

V E R I F I C A T I O N Does this sound like you? Read it aloud. Would a real person in your network read this and think it was worth their time? Is the claim you're making one you can genuinely support?

C U S T O M I S E If announcing something: lead with the "so what", why should the reader care before you describe what's happening If sharing expertise: include one specific, non-obvious insight rather than general advice If writing about experience: use a specific story, not a generalisation



W 1 0 , DRAFT A BLOG POST FROM NOTES TIME : 1 5 - 3 0 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: MEDIUM B

S I T U A T I O N You have a topic, a rough idea, or a set of notes that you want to turn into a publishable blog post. The notes are not polished prose, they are raw material.

STEP 1, EXTRACT AND STRUCTURE FROM NOTES

I want to write a blog post. Here are my rough notes: [paste notes]

Please extract from these notes: The central argument or insight The main supporting points Any examples or evidence What is missing that would strengthen the post

Then propose a structure: what order should these ideas go in to make the strongest post?

STEP 2, DEFINE THE POST

Using the proposed structure, I want you to draft a blog post with these specifications:

Target reader: [Who reads this, their background, what they care about] Publication: [Where it will be published] Tone: [my previous post example / formal-but-readable / conversational / authoritative] Length: [word count] Purpose: [Inform / Persuade / Entertain / Share experience]

Draft the post section by section. Start with the introduction, I'll review before you continue.

STEP 3, OPENING AND CONCLUSION

The opening paragraph and the closing paragraph are the two most important.

Opening: Replace the current opening with three alternative versions. One should open with a question, one with a specific story, one with a direct statement of the central argument.

Closing: The conclusion should end with something the reader can do or think about, not a summary. Rewrite it with a concrete, specific takeaway.

W**W10, Draft a Blog Post from Notes**

VERIFICATION Is the central argument clear? Has anyone made this point before in a nearly identical way, and if so, does your version add something? Are any specific claims, statistics, or examples accurate? Is the reading level and vocabulary appropriate for your audience?

!**W 1 1 , REPURPOSE CONTENT ACROSS FORMATS**

SITUATION You have a piece of content, a presentation, a report, an article, a talk, that contains value you want to extract and publish in different formats.

STEP 1 , CONTENT INVENTORY

I have a [content type] that I want to repurpose. [Attach or paste the content.]

Please identify: The three to five most valuable insights or ideas in this content
The most interesting or surprising point
Any statistics or specific evidence that would stand alone
Any stories or examples that would work as standalone content

STEP 2 , FORMAT PLANNING

I want to create content for: [List the formats: LinkedIn post / email newsletter / short video script / Twitter/X thread / FAQ document / How-to guide / Slide deck / etc.]

For each format I've listed, suggest which part of the original content would work best and how it should be adapted.

STEP 3 , EXECUTE BY FORMAT

Let's start with [first format].

[Using the relevant content identified in Step 2, apply the appropriate workflow for that format, W9 for LinkedIn, W10 for a blog post, etc.]

VERIFICATION Repurposed content should be adapted, not just repackaged. Verify that each piece works as a standalone without requiring the original context. Check that any statistics or claims retain their accuracy in the new format (statistics can be misleading when stripped of context).

!**W 1 2 , WRITE WEBSITE COPY**

SITUATION You need to write copy for a website page, a homepage, a services page, an about page, or a landing page, that converts readers into enquiries or customers.

STEP 1 , DEFINE THE PAGE

I need to write copy for a [page type] for [business/product name].

Business description: [What the business does, for whom, and what makes it different] Page purpose: [What this page should make the reader do or feel] Target visitor: [Who comes to this page, what they're looking for, what their concern or question is] Main message: [The single most important thing this page should communicate] Tone: [Professional / Friendly / Premium / Practical / Specialist] Any examples of websites with copy we admire: [links or descriptions]

Please draft this page.

STEP 2 , TEST THE COPY

Read this page as a sceptical first-time visitor who has never heard of [business name] and is comparing several options.

Does the headline make it immediately clear what this is for? Is the value proposition obvious within the first ten seconds? Are there any claims that a sceptical visitor would question? Is there a clear and compelling reason to take the next step? What is the main thing that would make someone leave this page?

STEP 3 , HEADLINES

The headline is the most important element. Write ten alternative headlines for this page. Range from direct to intriguing to benefit-led to question-based. I'll choose the strongest or combine elements from several.

VERIFICATION Does the copy accurately represent what the business actually does? Are any claims (testimonials, statistics, guarantees) genuine and verifiable? Have a target customer read it cold and ask them: "What do you think this company does? Would you contact them?"



RESEARCH AND LEARNING



W 1 3 , RESEARCH A TOPIC YOU KNOW NOTHING ABOUT



TIME : 1 5 - 3 0 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: MEDIUM BUILD

SITUATION You need to understand a topic you have little or no background in, a new sector, a technical subject, a policy area, a market, well enough to form a view or make a decision.

STEP 1, ESTABLISH ORIENTATION

I need to understand [topic]. I currently know [your current level, almost nothing / the basics / a little].

Please give me: 1. A plain-English overview: what this is, why it matters, who is involved 2. The key terminology I need to know to read about this intelligently 3. The main debates, disagreements, or open questions in this area 4. What the most important things I should read or watch to go deeper

Pitch this at someone who is intelligent but not yet knowledgeable about this topic.

STEP 2, IDENTIFY YOUR SPECIFIC NEED

My specific reason for learning about this: [Why you're researching this, decision, project, meeting, writing, general interest]

Given this context, what do I most need to understand? What can I safely deprioritise?

STEP 3, TEST UNDERSTANDING

Now ask me five questions about what we've just covered. Start simple and get more complex. For each question I answer, tell me whether my understanding is correct and where I should think more carefully.

VERIFICATION AI summaries of complex topics can oversimplify or, particularly for technical, scientific, or legal subjects, miss important nuance. Use this as a starting point, not a concluding source. For any topic where you will make significant decisions or public claims, follow up with primary sources. Check the AI briefing for any claims that seem surprising, they may be wrong.

CUSTOMISE For legal or regulatory topics: explicitly note "flag any areas of ongoing debate or uncertainty" and add "I'll need to verify

W

W13, Research a Topic You Know Nothing About

the current regulatory position from official sources" For scientific topics: ask for the quality of evidence behind major claims For market or commercial topics: ask AI to flag the uncertainty inherent in market estimates

!

W 1 4 , UNDERSTAND A COMPLEX DOCUMENT

!

TIME : 3 0 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK

S I T U A T I O N You have a document, a contract, a policy, a technical report, a legal opinion, that you need to understand but that is written in language that does not make understanding easy.

STEP 1 , INITIAL READ

Please read this document. [Attach document.]

First pass: What type of document is this? What is its purpose? What are the main sections? Who are the parties or stakeholders involved?

Then: what does this document actually mean in plain English? Give me a summary a non-specialist could act on.

STEP 2 , SPECIFIC QUESTIONS

I want to understand the following specific aspects of this document:

- [Your first specific question, e.g., "What are our obligations under section 4?"]
- [Second question]
- [Third question]

For each, tell me: what does the document say, what does it mean in plain language, and is there anything ambiguous or unclear about it?

STEP 3 , RISK AND ACTION IDENTIFICATION

From a practical standpoint: What are the most important obligations or deadlines in this document? What are the main risks this document creates or addresses? What actions do I or my organisation need to take as a result of this document? Are there any clauses or provisions that seem unusual or that I should take advice on?

V E R I F I C A T I O N For contracts, legal opinions, and regulatory documents: the plain-English summary is an aid to understanding, not a legal substitute. Any action taken on the basis of a document should reference the original text. For significant legal or financial matters, consult a qualified professional.



W 1 5 , COM PARE OPTIONS BEFORE A DECISION



TIME : 3 0 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK

S I T U A T I O N You need to choose between options, suppliers, approaches, products, strategies, and want a structured comparison to inform the decision.

STEP 1 , DEFINE THE DECISION

I need to compare [options] to [make a decision].

Context: [Why this decision matters and what's at stake] Decision-maker: [Who will make the final decision and what they care about] Options to compare: [List them] Evaluation criteria: [What matters, list them in rough order of importance] Constraints: [Budget, timeline, technical requirements, regulatory requirements] Information available: [What you know about each option, attach documents if relevant]

STEP 2 , STRUCTURED COM PARISON

Compare [options] against the criteria I've specified.

Format: A table where rows are evaluation criteria and columns are options. For each cell, provide a brief assessment (not just a rating, a sentence or two of substance).

After the table: a one-paragraph narrative on each option summarising its main strengths and main weaknesses.

STEP 3 , RECOMMEND ATION AND CHALLENGE

Based on the comparison, what would your recommendation be? What is the main argument for each of the other options over the recommended one?

Then: challenge the recommendation. What would have to be true for a different option to be the right choice?

VERIFICATION Any specific claims about each option should be verified against the options' own documentation. AI comparisons are only as good as the information provided, if you have incomplete information about one option, flag this explicitly in the decision record. For significant procurement decisions, this structured analysis is a useful starting point, not a substitute for due diligence.



W 1 6 , LEARN A NEW SKILL FASTER TIME : 1 5 - 3 0 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: MEDIUM BUILD

SITUATION You want to learn something, a tool, a technique, a process, a domain, and want to use AI to accelerate the learning.

This is not limited to office or professional-services work. A teacher learning a new classroom tool, a healthcare worker learning a documentation process, or a creative professional

learning unfamiliar software can use the same workflow, provided the current training, safety, or professional requirements are supplied and checked.

STEP 1, MAP THE SKILL

I want to learn [skill/topic/tool].

My current level: [Complete beginner / Have the basics / Some intermediate experience] My purpose: [Why I want to learn this, be specific about what I want to be able to do] My constraints: [Time available, how I learn best, any specific challenges]

Please give me: 1. A clear learning path, what do I need to learn first, second, third? 2. The concepts that are most important to understand early (getting these wrong means struggling later) 3. The most common mistakes beginners make 4. How long should each stage realistically take?

STEP 2, ACTIVE PRACTICE DESIGN

Design a practice plan for the next [time period] that builds this skill through doing, not just reading.

Each practice exercise should: Be achievable in [time per session] Build on the previous exercise Produce something I can assess myself

Include: what "good enough to move on" looks like for each stage.

W**W16, Learn a New Skill Faster****STEP 3 , TEACH ME AND TEST ME**

Let's work through the first concept: [topic from learning path].

Explain it clearly. Then test my understanding with a question. When I answer, tell me whether I'm right, where I've misunderstood, and what I should focus on.

Continue until I can explain this concept back to you correctly in my own words.

V E R I F I C A T I O N AI-generated learning plans may miss important nuance, especially for professional skills where regulatory, safety, or ethical dimensions matter. For professional certifications, verify that the learning path aligns with the actual certification curriculum. For technical skills, test your understanding through actual practice, not just by being able to answer AI's questions.

!**PERSONAL PRODUCTIVITY****!****W 1 7 , PLAN A PROJECT TIME : 3 0 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK**

S I T U A T I O N You have a project to deliver, at work or in your personal life, and you want to plan it properly before starting.

STEP 1 , DEFINE THE PROJECT

I need to plan a project. Here is what I know:

What the project produces: [The end deliverable] Purpose: [Why this project matters / what problem it solves] Deadline: [When it must be complete] Resources: [What time, budget, people, or tools are available] Constraints: [What you cannot do / what is fixed] Dependencies: [What you're waiting for / what others are doing] Risks: [What might go wrong] Key stakeholders: [Who needs to be kept informed or who can block this]

STEP 2 , BUILD THE PLAN

Please develop a project plan that includes: 1. Work breakdown: what are all the tasks required to deliver this? 2. Sequence: which tasks depend on which? 3. Timeline: working back from the deadline, when does each task need to happen? 4. Critical path: which tasks, if delayed, will delay the whole project? 5. Milestones: what are the key checkpoints?

Present as a structured plan I can use to track progress.

STEP 3 , RISK AND CONTINGENCY

For this project, what are the three most likely things to go wrong? For each, what is the early warning sign, and what should I do if it happens?

VERIFICATION Have someone with relevant experience review the plan, AI planning is good at structure but may miss domain-specific risks or dependencies. Verify timelines are realistic against your actual experience with similar work.



W 18 , PROCESS A BACKLOG OF TASKS TIME : 30 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK

SITUATION You have an overwhelming list of tasks, projects, emails, or obligations and need to bring order to it.

STEP 1, CAPTURE EVERYTHING

I'm going to paste in everything that is on my to-do list, in my inbox, or on my mind as outstanding. [Paste raw list, it doesn't need to be organised.]

First pass: read through this and tell me: How many distinct things are here? Are there any that are really the same thing? Are there any that seem more urgent than I might realise?

STEP 2, TRIAGE

Now help me triage these tasks:

For each task, categorise it: 1. URGENT & IMPORTANT: Must happen this week 2. IMPORTANT but not urgent: Schedule for this month 3. URGENT but not important: Could be delegated or handled quickly 4. NEITHER: Question whether this needs to happen at all

Flag any task where you can't categorise it and tell me why.

STEP 3, WEEK PLAN

Based on what's in Category 1 (urgent and important), help me plan this week.

My available time this week is approximately [hours/days]. Fixed commitments already in the calendar: [list them]

Which of the Category 1 tasks should happen which day? What is a realistic week that is ambitious but achievable?



PARTV - 25 REAL-WORLD WORKFLOWS

VERIFICATION Review the prioritisation against your own judgment, AI may prioritise based on what seems externally important without knowing what your actual professional context makes most critical. Check whether any deadline-driven items have been correctly identified as urgent.



W 19 , DRAFT A DIFFICULT PERSONAL MESSAGE



TIME : ABOUT 5 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: QUICK WIN

S I T U A T I O N You need to write something personal that is emotionally complex, an apology, a message to someone you've lost touch with, a difficult family communication, a message declining an invitation in a way that preserves the relationship.

STEP 1 , ES TABLISH THE SITU ATION

I need to write a personal message and I want to get it right.

Situation: [What has happened and why this message is necessary] **Recipient:** [Who this is to, relationship, history] **What I want to achieve:** [The outcome I'm hoping for] **What I'm worried about:** [How it might go wrong] **My honest feelings:** [As much as you want to share, this helps AI understand the emotional register] **Tone required:** [Warm / Apologetic / Careful / Direct / Affectionate]

Please draft this message.

STEP 2 , TONE CHECK

Read this message from the recipient's perspective.

How might they feel receiving this? Does it say what I intended, or could it be read differently? Is there anything that might land wrong even though it wasn't intended to? Is the length right for the situation?

STEP 3 , A LTERN ATIVES

Write two alternative versions of this message: One that is slightly more direct One that is slightly warmer

I'll choose elements from whichever feels most right.

V E R I F I C A T I O N Read the final draft aloud. Does it sound like you? Would the recipient recognise your voice in it? If the message is truly important, sleep on it before sending, AI drafts can be technically good but emotionally wrong in ways that a night's consideration reveals.



W 2 0 , PRE PARE FOR A JOB INTERVIEW TIME : 1 5 - 3 0 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: MEDIUM BU

S I T U A T I O N You have a job interview, internal or external, and want to prepare seriously rather than just hoping for the best.

STEP 1 , RESEARCH

I have a job interview for the role of [title] at [organisation].

Please help me prepare.

What I know about the organisation: [paste or link available information] **The job description:** [attach or paste] **My relevant experience:** [brief summary] **My main strengths for this role:** [your view] **My main**

concerns about this role: [what you're less sure about]

Based on the job description and organisation, what should I know before this interview?

STEP 2, ANTICIPATE QUESTIONS

Based on the role and organisation, what are the fifteen most likely questions I will be asked? Include:
Questions about my experience and background
Questions about why I want this role
Competency-based questions ("tell me about a time when...")
Questions about my knowledge of the organisation
Difficult or challenging questions I should be ready for

For each question, note what the interviewer is likely trying to learn from it.

STEP 3, PREPARE ANSWERS

Let's prepare my answers to the five hardest questions from the list.

For each, I'll give you my rough answer. You will: Identify what is strong about it
Identify what is missing or could be clearer
Suggest how to make it more compelling

Let's start with: [first hard question]. My rough answer: [your answer]

STEP 4, QUESTIONS TO ASK

What are the best questions I could ask the interviewer? Suggest five to eight questions that:
Demonstrate I've prepared and thought about the role
Help me genuinely assess whether this is the right role for me
Are not questions whose answers are on the website

Avoid: questions that seem presumptuous, overly salary-focused, or that suggest I haven't done basic research.

VERIFICATION Verify all company facts before the interview, AI's information may be outdated. Check the company's website, recent news, and LinkedIn for current information. Practise answers aloud, answers that read well often sound unnatural when spoken. Time your answers to key questions.

W

W20, Prepare for a Job Interview

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HOME AND LIFE

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W 2 1 , PLAN A TRIP TIME : 3 0 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK

S I T U A T I O N You want to plan a trip, city break, holiday, business travel, and want more than a generic list of tourist attractions.

STEP 1 , DEFINE THE TRIP

I'm planning a trip and want help making it as good as possible.

Destination: [Where] Dates/duration: [When, how long] Who is travelling: [Adults/children/ages, special requirements] Type of trip: [Relaxation / Culture / Adventure / City exploration / Family / Romantic / Other] Interests: [What you genuinely enjoy] Things you want to avoid: [Tourist traps, certain types of activity, etc.] Budget level: [Budget / Mid-range / Premium] Existing bookings: [What's already confirmed] What you've already decided to do: [Any fixed elements]

STEP 2 , PERSONALISED RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on this, give me: 1. The things in [destination] that genuinely match my interests, not the standard tourist list 2. The things most people do that I might want to skip given what I've told you 3. Practical considerations specific to this trip that I should think about in advance

STEP 3 , ITINERARY

Draft a day-by-day itinerary for [number of days].

Build it around my interests and priorities, not a generic tourist circuit. Be realistic about travel time between locations. Flag anything that needs advance booking. Leave space, don't over-schedule.

VERIFICATION Verify opening hours, prices, and booking requirements from current official sources, AI information may be outdated. For international travel, check current visa, health, and entry requirements from official government sources. Book anything time-sensitive or popular in advance.



W 2 2 , UNDERSTAND A CONTRACT OR LEGAL DOCUMENT



TIME : 30 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK

SITUATION You have received a contract, terms and conditions, rental agreement, or legal document that you need to understand before signing or acting on.

STEP 1 , PLAIN - ENGLISH SUMMARY

Please read this [document type]. [Attach document.]

Give me a plain-English summary: What is this document? What does it obligate me to do? What does it obligate the other party to do? What are the most important terms? When does it begin and end?

STEP 2 , RED FLAG IDENTIFICATION

Now read this document more carefully for potential concerns.

Flag: Any unusual clauses that differ from what you'd typically expect Any terms that limit my rights significantly Any financial obligations beyond the obvious ones Any automatic renewal or escalation clauses Any clauses where my obligations are unclear or broad Anything I should ask the other party to clarify or change before signing

STEP 3 , QUESTIONS TO RAISE

Based on what you've found, what specific questions should I raise with [the other party / my solicitor / the landlord] before signing? List them in order of importance.

VERIFICATION This analysis is a tool for understanding and preparation, not legal advice. For any contract involving significant financial commitment, important rights, or professional risk, consult a qualified solicitor. AI can misread or oversimplify legal language. Always read the actual contract before signing, do not rely solely on an AI summary.



W 2 3 , GET A SECOND OPINION ON A HEALTH QUESTION



TIME : 3 0 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK

SITUATION You have a health question, a symptom you want to understand, a diagnosis you've been given and want to learn more about, a medication you want to understand better, and want to use AI as a starting point for a better-informed conversation with your doctor.

STEP 1 , STATE THE QUESTION CLEARLY

I want to understand [health topic] better so I can have a more informed conversation with my doctor.

Context: [Brief background, age, general health context if relevant, what has already been discussed with a healthcare professional] My specific question: [What I want to understand] What I already know: [Any information you've already received from a healthcare professional]

Please explain [topic] in plain language. This is to help me understand, not to replace medical advice.

STEP 2 , QUESTIONS FOR YOUR DOCTOR

Based on what you've explained, what would be the most useful questions for me to ask my doctor? I want to: Understand my situation better Know what my options are Understand what I should be monitoring or watching for Know when I should seek urgent attention

VERIFICATION AI is not a substitute for professional medical advice. For any health question with significant consequences, speak to a qualified healthcare professional. AI information about health topics may be incomplete, out of date, or not applicable to your specific situation. Never adjust medication, ignore professional advice, or make significant health decisions based solely on AI output.



WRITING AND EDITING



W 2 4 , EDIT AND IMPROVE YOUR OWN WRITING TIME : ABOUT 5 MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: QU

SITUATION You have written something, an article, a report, a proposal, an email, and want to improve it before it goes out. You know it could be better but aren't sure exactly how.

STEP 1, DIAGNOSTIC READ

Please read this piece of writing. [Attach or paste the document.]

Give me a diagnostic before you suggest any changes: What is the main argument or purpose of this piece? What is working well? What are the main weaknesses? Where did you lose interest or find the writing unclear?

Do not make any changes yet, just diagnose.

STEP 2, TARGETED EDITING

Now, based on the diagnosis, help me improve this piece.

Priority: [Which weakness is most important to fix first?]

Please: 1. Rewrite the weakest paragraph, show me what better looks like 2. Suggest structural changes if needed, should anything be moved, cut, or added? 3. Flag any sentences that are unclear or that say less than they should

Do not over-edit, preserve my voice. Make it better, not different.



PART V - 25 REAL-WORLD WORKFLOWS

STEP 3, LINE EDITING

Now do a line edit pass on this document.

Look for: Sentences that are too long or too complex Passive voice where active would be stronger Filler words and phrases that add length without meaning Any word used repeatedly that should be varied Anything that could be expressed more precisely

For each change: show the original and the improved version, and note briefly why the change helps.

V E R I F I C A T I O N Read the final edited version aloud. Does it still sound like you? Has AI edited out your voice along with your weaknesses? It is better to keep a few imperfections that are genuinely yours than to have a technically polished piece that reads like it was written by someone else.



W 2 5 , TURN ROUGH NOTES INTO A POLISHED DOCUMENT



TIME : 3 0 + MINUTES-COMPLEXITY: DEEP WORK

S I T U A T I O N You have rough notes, a voice memo transcript, scattered thoughts, or a messy draft that needs to become a proper document. The content is there, it just needs structure and polish.

STEP 1, MAKE SENSE OF THE MATERIAL

I have rough material that I need to turn into [document type]. [Attach or paste notes.]

First pass: help me understand what I have. What are the main ideas in this material? What is the implied argument or narrative? What is well-developed versus what is sketchy? What is missing that the final document will need?

STEP 2, BUILD THE STRUCTURE

Propose a structure for [document type] based on what's in the notes.

I need the document to: Achieve: [purpose] For: [audience] In approximately: [word count or length]

For each proposed section, note: what content from my notes goes here, and what will need to be added.

STEP 3, DRAFT

Now draft [document type] section by section using my notes as source material.

Preserve my ideas and voice. Add structure and polish, do not add new ideas or content I haven't indicated.

Start with [first section]. I'll review before you continue to the next.

STEP 4, FINAL PASS

Now read the complete draft as a whole. Does it flow? Does each section lead naturally to the next? Is there anything that still sounds like rough notes rather than finished prose? Produce a final clean version.



PART V - 25 REAL-WORLD WORKFLOWS

VERIFICATION Read the final document as if you were reading it for the first time. Is anything missing that you intended to include? Has anything been included that you didn't intend? Does the document accurately represent your thinking, or has it drifted toward something slightly different in the polishing process?

This completes the twenty-five real-world workflows. The library is designed to be used selectively, find the workflow that matches your situation, adapt the placeholders to your specifics, and use the verification steps before trusting the output.

Part VI covers the habits and practices that make these workflows reliable: how to verify output, what AI consistently gets wrong, and how to build an AI practice that serves you well over time.



W25, Turn Rough Notes into a Polished Document

PART V | The AI User's Playbook

The twenty-five workflows in Part V are only as good as the habits that surround them. A technically perfect workflow can still produce embarrassing or harmful output if the result goes unverified. A strong AI practice is built on something less glamorous than clever prompts: the discipline of knowing when to trust output, what to check, and how to catch errors before they matter.



IN THIS PART

C H A P T E R 2 0 C H A P T E R 2 1 How to Verify AI Output What AI Gets Wrong (Consistently)

C H A P T E R 2 2 C H A P T E R 2 3 Calibrating Trust Building Your AI Habits

C H A P T E R 2 4 Keeping Up Without Burning Out

Part VI is about that discipline. It is, in many ways, the most important part of the book.